CANDIDATE INSTRUCTION MANUAL

IT Support Group Project

The Difficult Ticket: Technical Resolution & Professional Communication Challenge

Group size: 4 people | Duration: 2 weeks | Deliverables: Written report + live presentation & role-play

Read this manual in full before your first team meeting.

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1. Welcome & How to Use This Manual

Congratulations on starting this project. This manual is yours to keep, mark up, and refer back to throughout the two weeks. It is written to be self-contained: if you and your team follow it step by step, you should never be unsure of what to do next or who is responsible for it.

A few ground rules for using this manual:

- Every team member should read the entire manual, not just their own role section. You need to understand what your teammates are accountable for in order to support them and hold them to it.
- Section 7 ("Your Role") is the heart of this manual. Read your own role card closely, then read the other three so you understand the full picture.
- The templates in Section 8 are meant to be copied into a shared document (spreadsheet, shared doc, or whiteboard tool) on Day 1 and used daily — they are not just for show.
- Nothing in this manual is set in stone except the deadlines, the four roles, and the rubric. You have freedom to choose your own technical fault, your own "difficult user" personality, and your own communication framework.

2. Project Overview

This project combines two skill sets that every IT support professional needs: the technical ability to diagnose and fix problems, and the interpersonal ability to manage people — especially people who are frustrated, stressed, or difficult — while doing it. In the real world these two things are never separate; a perfectly fixed ticket handled with poor communication still damages trust, and a beautifully handled conversation about a problem that never actually gets fixed helps no one.

You will work in a group of four. Each of you owns one clearly defined role for the full two weeks. Your group will jointly resolve a realistic IT support scenario (Section 4), and present your resolution back as a written incident report plus a live presentation that includes a role-played conversation with a frustrated user.

This project is built around individual accountability inside a team. That means the group's success depends on every person visibly doing their part — and the assessment is designed specifically to reward that, and to make it obvious if it doesn't happen. Read Section 5 carefully to understand how and why.

3. Learning Objectives

By the end of this project you should be able to:

1. Apply a structured IT troubleshooting process to diagnose and resolve a realistic technical fault.
2. Use specific, learnable communication techniques to manage a frustrated or escalating stakeholder.
3. Apply a named conflict-resolution or de-escalation framework in a real (role-played) interaction, not just describe it in theory.
4. Produce clear, professional-standard IT documentation, including ticket notes and a formal incident report.
5. Track and evidence your own individual contribution within a team project.
6. Give direct, constructive feedback to teammates, and receive it professionally.

4. The Scenario

Your group provides IT support for a fictional mid-sized company, "Meridian Logistics." One department manager — under real deadline pressure — has been experiencing a recurring technical problem. Over the course of about a week, they contact IT support three times. Each contact is more frustrated than the last.

4.1 Choose your fault

Agree as a group on one realistic, recurring IT fault. Examples (choose one, or propose your own):

- Intermittent VPN disconnections that drop the user out of video calls.
- A shared network drive that repeatedly loses permissions, blocking access to shared files.
- A printer/print-server fault that fails intermittently for one department only.
- A company laptop that randomly loses wifi connectivity, worse in certain rooms.
- An email/calendar sync fault causing missed meeting invites.

Your fault must be realistic and technically consistent — the Technical Support Lead should be able to explain, step by step, both what was wrong and how it was diagnosed and fixed.

4.2 Choose your "difficult user" persona

Agree on a personality for the frustrated user your Team Lead will handle in the live role-play. Some starting points:

- The Escalator — goes straight to threatening to involve senior management or their director.
- The Blamer — insists the problem is entirely IT's fault and gets personal.
- The Time-Pressured Panicker — isn't rude, but is highly anxious and talks over you because they have a deadline in an hour.
- The Passive-Aggressive — technically polite, but sarcastic, cc's people unnecessarily, and leaves pointed comments in writing.

Pick one persona and stay consistent with it across your written tickets and your live role-play — consistency is part of what makes the scenario feel real.

4.3 Example escalating ticket sequence

Below is a template sequence you can adapt to your chosen fault. Rewrite the specifics, but keep the escalating pattern — polite, then frustrated, then formal/threatening.

Ticket 1 (Day 1 — polite, low urgency)

> *"Hi IT team, I've noticed [fault] happening a couple of times this week. Not urgent, but could someone take a look when they get a chance? Thanks, [User]."*

Ticket 2 (Day 3 — following up, visibly frustrated)

> *"Hi again — this is now happening daily and it's starting to really affect my team's work. I flagged this two days ago and haven't heard anything back. Can someone please prioritise this? [User]."*

Ticket 3 (Day 5 — escalated, cc'ing a director)

> *"This is now the third time I've raised this and nothing has changed. My team missed [deadline/deliverable] because of this. I'm cc'ing [Director] as I need this resolved today. [User]."*

Your group should write your own version of this three-ticket sequence, matched to your chosen fault and persona, and include it in your incident report (Section 10).

5. How This Project Works: Accountability, Explained

This project is designed around one core idea: in a real workplace, no one can hide inside a team. Your manager, your colleagues, and your clients can all tell whether you delivered what you said you would. This project recreates that in a low-stakes setting, so you can practise it before it matters for real.

Here's what that means in practice:

- Every one of the four roles has its own named deliverable (Section 7) that is graded individually. If your role's deliverable is missing or weak, it affects your mark specifically — not just the group's.
- You keep a personal Individual Accountability Log (Section 8.2) for the full two weeks. This is your evidence of what you committed to and what you actually did.
- The group maintains one shared Task Tracker (Section 8.1) that is visible to everyone at all times — there should never be any doubt about who owns what or whether it's on track.
- Marking is split 70% individual / 30% group (see Section 11), so your own effort is protected — a teammate under-delivering cannot drag your mark down as much as it would in a fully shared mark, and equally, you cannot coast on your teammates' work.

If you're worried a teammate isn't delivering: say so directly and early, in your stand-up (Section 6) — not just in your private log at the end. Accountability is a two-way responsibility: you're accountable for your own work, and you're accountable for surfacing problems early enough for the team to fix them.

6. Timeline — Day-by-Day Plan

This plan assumes a 10 working-day (2-week) project. If your programme runs on a different calendar, keep the same order of stages and compress or stretch the days proportionally.

Day	Stage	What must happen
Day 1	Kick-off	Form your group. Read this manual individually, then meet as a team. Assign the four roles (Section 7). Agree your technical fault and user persona (Section 4). Set up your shared Task Tracker (Section 8.1). Hold your Kick-off Meeting (Section 8.3) and complete your Team Charter.
Day 2	Planning	Team Lead drafts the contact/escalation plan for the user. Technical Support Lead begins researching the chosen fault. Training & Development Coordinator begins researching communication frameworks (Section 9). Documentation & QA Lead sets up the incident report template and the shared tracker.
Day 3	Investigate	Technical Support Lead finalises the technical diagnosis and drafts the fix, in plain language as well as technical language. First stand-up: 10 minutes, each person states what they did yesterday, what they're doing today, and any blockers.
Day 4	Research & draft	Training & Development Coordinator finalises their chosen communication framework and prepares the internal training session. Team Lead drafts the role-play script based on the escalating ticket sequence (Section 4.3).
Day 5	Internal training	Training & Development Coordinator delivers a 10-minute internal training session to the whole team, teaching the chosen framework. Second stand-up. Documentation & QA Lead drafts the ticket notes section of the incident report.
Day 6	Build	Team Lead and the person playing "the user" rehearse the role-play once, using the framework just taught. Documentation & QA Lead drafts the full incident report using material from Roles 1, 2 and 4.
Day 7	Rehearse & review	Full rehearsal of the role-play, timed (aim for 5–8 minutes). Training & Development Coordinator observes and gives structured feedback (Section 7, Role 4). Documentation & QA Lead quality-checks the full incident report for accuracy, consistency and tone.
Day 8	Peer test	Third stand-up. If possible, run your role-play once for another group or a facilitator and collect feedback. Revise the script, documentation, and presentation slides based on feedback.
Day 9	Finalise	Final rehearsal of the full presentation (slides + role-play) as a complete run-through, timed. Everyone finalises and submits their Individual Accountability Log. Documentation & QA Lead finalises the Task Tracker.
Day 10	Deliver	Submit the written Incident Report. Deliver the live presentation and role-play demonstration. Submit all Individual Accountability Logs and the final Task Tracker.

Stand-ups (Days 3, 5, 8) should take no more than 10–15 minutes. Each person answers three questions only: What did I complete since the last stand-up? What am I doing next? Is anything blocking me? The Team Lead runs these and notes any blockers in the Task Tracker.

7. Your Role

Read your own role card in full before Day 1. Then skim the other three so you understand how your work connects to theirs. All four roles are equally weighted in importance — there is no "lead" role that outranks the others; "Team Lead" here specifically means leading the client relationship, not being in charge of your teammates.

Role 1 — Team Lead & Client Relationship Manager

Role 1 — Team Lead & Client Relationship Manager	
Purpose	You own the relationship with the frustrated user from first ticket to resolution, and you lead the live conversation where the user's frustration has to be managed directly. You are the public face of professional communication under pressure, and you also keep the team's schedule honest.
Skills you'll practise	Professional written and verbal communication; de-escalation and active listening; leading a live, unscripted-feeling conversation; light project coordination.
Your deliverable	The full role-play script and its delivery in the live presentation; the meeting/stand-up log showing you tracked the team's progress.
Evidence you must produce	Notes from each stand-up showing you checked in on every teammate's progress; a short written reflection (200–300 words) on how you applied the communication framework during the live conversation, including at least one thing that didn't go as planned and how you adapted.

Day-by-day for this role

- Day 1: Help agree the fault and persona. Set up and share the Task Tracker link. Run the Kick-off Meeting.
- Day 2: Draft how the user would realistically make contact three times (matches Section 4.3). Share with the team for input.
- Day 3–4: Run stand-up. Draft the role-play script once the Training & Development Coordinator has confirmed the framework you'll use.
- Day 5–7: Learn and practise the framework. Rehearse the role-play with whoever is playing the user. Incorporate feedback.
- Day 8–9: Peer test, revise, do a full final rehearsal. Write your reflection.
- Day 10: Deliver the live role-play as part of the presentation.

Tips for success

- Don't over-script your side of the conversation word-for-word — know your key moves (acknowledge, clarify, commit, follow up) and let the actual words come naturally. Over-rehearsed role-plays read as fake.
- Practise sitting with the user's frustration for a few seconds before responding, rather than jumping straight to a fix. This is one of the most common and most valuable things to get right.
- Keep your stand-ups short and focused on facts (done / doing / blocked) — don't let them become status meetings.

Role 2 — Technical Support Lead

Role 2 — Technical Support Lead	
Purpose	You own the technical credibility of the whole project. Your diagnosis and fix have to be realistic, internally consistent, and explainable — both to your teammates and, in plain language, to a non-technical user.
Skills you'll practise	Structured troubleshooting methodology; technical writing; translating technical detail into plain language; answering follow-up questions under pressure.
Your deliverable	The technical diagnosis and resolution write-up, feeding into both the incident report and the role-play.
Evidence you must produce	A step-by-step troubleshooting log (what you checked, in what order, and what you found at each step) and readiness to answer live follow-up technical questions during the presentation.

Day-by-day for this role

- Day 1–2: Confirm the chosen fault with the team. Begin researching how this type of fault is typically diagnosed in real IT support (search reputable IT/support documentation, not just guesswork).
- Day 3: Finalise your diagnosis and fix. Write it two ways: full technical version, and a plain-language version a non-technical user could understand.
- Day 4–6: Hand your plain-language explanation to the Team Lead for the role-play script. Support the Documentation & QA Lead in writing the technical sections of the incident report.
- Day 7–9: Review the incident report's technical accuracy. Prepare to answer likely follow-up questions ("why did this keep happening?", "how do we stop it recurring?").
- Day 10: Be ready to field technical questions live during the presentation.

Tips for success

- Write your troubleshooting log as you go, in the order you actually worked through it — don't reconstruct a neat version afterwards. A slightly messy, real diagnostic path is more credible than a suspiciously tidy one.
- Always prepare the plain-language version. A technically perfect fix explained in jargon will land badly with a frustrated, non-technical user — and that's exactly the mistake this project is designed to help you avoid.
- Think about root cause, not just the symptom fix. What would you recommend to stop this recurring? That answer strengthens both your technical mark and the incident report.

Role 3 — Documentation & Quality Assurance Lead

Role 3 — Documentation & Quality Assurance Lead	
Purpose	You own accuracy, consistency, and professional tone across everything the team produces in writing. You also own the shared Task Tracker — you are the person the team relies on to know, at a glance, whether the project is on track.
Skills you'll practise	Technical/business writing; proofreading and quality control; project tracking; consolidating input from multiple people into one consistent document.
Your deliverable	The final written Incident Report (Section 10.1) and the completed, up-to-date Task Tracker.

Evidence you must produce	A version history or edit trail showing the incident report improved over drafts (dated versions or tracked changes), and a fully completed Task Tracker showing what every teammate delivered and when, including any missed deadlines and how they were resolved.

Day-by-day for this role

- Day 1: Set up the shared Task Tracker (Section 8.1) and the incident report template (Section 10.1 headings). Share both with the team.
- Day 2–3: Update the tracker daily as tasks are assigned. Begin drafting the ticket-notes section of the incident report from Role 1's material.
- Day 4–6: Incorporate the technical write-up from Role 2 and the framework explainer from Role 4 into the report. Keep tone and formatting consistent throughout — this is your main job.
- Day 7–8: Full quality pass on the entire incident report: check facts are consistent across sections (e.g. dates and fault details match), check tone is professional throughout, check spelling/grammar.
- Day 9: Finalise the Task Tracker and confirm every role's deliverable and accountability evidence is complete.
- Day 10: Submit the final incident report and tracker.

Tips for success

- Update the Task Tracker daily, even briefly — a tracker that's only updated at the end isn't evidence of anything.
- When quality-checking, read the report once purely for factual consistency (do the dates, names, and fault details agree everywhere?) and a second time purely for tone and clarity — trying to do both at once means you miss things.
- It's part of your role to (respectfully) chase teammates for material you're waiting on — don't just wait silently and then report the gap at the end.

Role 4 — Training & Development Coordinator

Role 4 — Training & Development Coordinator	
Purpose	You own the professional-development content for the whole team: you choose and teach the communication/de-escalation framework the group will use, and you evaluate how well it's actually applied in rehearsal.
Skills you'll practise	Research and synthesis; teaching/facilitation; structured, constructive feedback; self-directed learning.
Your deliverable	The internal training session you deliver to the team, and the post-project team debrief you lead.
Evidence you must produce	A one-page framework brief (used to train the team) and written feedback notes from at least one observed rehearsal, plus a short summary of the team debrief you led at the end of the project.

Day-by-day for this role

- Day 1–2: Research 2–3 communication or de-escalation frameworks (see the Toolkit in Section 9 as a starting point) and choose one that fits your team's chosen user persona.
- Day 3–4: Prepare a one-page brief explaining the framework simply, with at least one example phrase or step for each stage.

- Day 5: Deliver a 10-minute internal training session to the team, teaching them the framework before the role-play is rehearsed.
- Day 6–7: Observe the role-play rehearsal. Give specific, constructive feedback tied directly to the framework ("you moved to problem-solving before fully acknowledging the frustration — try holding that acknowledgement a beat longer").
- Day 8–9: Observe the peer-test/final rehearsal. Update your feedback notes.
- Day 10: Lead a short (10–15 minute) team debrief after the presentation — what worked, what you'd do differently, one thing each person will take into future work.

Tips for success

- Choose a framework that's simple enough to actually be usable live under pressure — a framework with 3–4 clear steps beats a complex model no one can remember mid-conversation.
- Give feedback on specific moments, not general impressions. "Good job" or "that felt a bit rushed" isn't as useful as pointing to the exact moment and what could change there.
- Your debrief at the end is a real deliverable, not an afterthought — prepare a few open questions in advance (e.g. "what was the hardest moment to handle, and why?").

8. Team Charter & Accountability Templates

Set these up on Day 1, in a shared document or spreadsheet everyone can access and edit. Copy the table structures below.

8.1 Shared Task Tracker

Maintained by the Documentation & QA Lead, updated by everyone. Add a new row for every task, however small.

Owner	Task	Due date	Status	Evidence / link

8.2 Individual Accountability Log

One per person, kept privately and submitted individually at the end. Add a new entry after every work session, however short.

Date	What I committed to	What I actually completed	Gap / reason (if any)	What I need from a teammate

Be honest in this log, including about gaps or delays. It is more valuable as evidence of real accountability — including how you handled a slip — than as a record of a project that went perfectly.

8.3 Kick-off Meeting Agenda (Day 1)

Run this as your first team meeting, ideally 45–60 minutes. Team Lead facilitates.

7. Introductions: one strength you bring and one thing you want to get better at from this project.
8. Assign the four roles (Section 7) — by preference where possible, otherwise by discussion.
9. Agree your technical fault and difficult-user persona (Section 4).

10. Set up the shared Task Tracker and Individual Accountability Logs.
11. Agree communication norms: how and when you'll contact each other, and what "blocked" or "falling behind" should trigger (e.g. flag it within 24 hours, don't wait for the next stand-up).
12. Confirm the three stand-up dates/times for the two weeks (Section 6).
13. Confirm the Day 10 presentation slot and format.

9. Communication & Conflict-Resolution Toolkit

Use this as a starting point for research — you don't have to use exactly these frameworks, but they're well-established and a good foundation. The Training & Development Coordinator should pick one (or blend elements of two) rather than trying to teach all of them.

9.1 Active Listening — the foundation for everything else

Before any framework, active listening is the base skill: give full attention, don't interrupt, reflect back what you heard before responding, and check you've understood correctly before moving to solutions.

> *Example reflecting phrase: "So what I'm hearing is this has now cost your team a deadline, and you need certainty it won't happen again — is that right?"*

9.2 DESC Scripting

A structured way to raise or respond to a difficult situation in four steps:

- Describe — state the facts of the situation objectively, without judgement.
- Express — say how the situation is affecting things (or acknowledge how it's affecting the other person).
- Specify — state clearly what will happen next.
- Consequences — explain the positive outcome of resolving it this way.

9.3 LEAP Method

Commonly used in de-escalation training, especially with someone who feels unheard:

- Listen — let them fully say what's wrong without interruption.
- Empathise — acknowledge the impact on them specifically, not just the technical problem.
- Agree — find something true you can agree with, even if you can't agree with everything.
- Partner — move to "let's fix this together" language rather than "I will fix this for you."

9.4 HEARD Model

Often used in customer-facing service recovery:

- Hear — let them explain fully.
- Empathise — acknowledge their frustration is legitimate.
- Apologise — for the impact, even if not for fault directly ("I'm sorry this has disrupted your week").
- Resolve — state the concrete fix and timeline.
- Diagnose — after resolution, identify what will prevent recurrence.

9.5 Phrases that help vs. phrases that escalate

Tends to escalate	Tends to de-escalate
"That's not actually our fault."	"I can see why that's been frustrating — let's get it sorted."
"You'll need to calm down."	"I want to understand exactly what's happened — can you talk me through it?"
"There's nothing I can do."	"Here's what I can do right now, and here's the next step after that."

"I already explained this."	"Let me go over it again so we're both clear."

10. Deliverable Specifications

10.1 Written Incident Report

Length: roughly 3–5 pages. Structure (use these as your headings):

14. Summary — one paragraph: what happened and how it was resolved.
15. Ticket History — your three escalating ticket messages (Section 4.3), with dates.
16. Technical Diagnosis — Role 2's troubleshooting log and root cause.
17. Resolution — the fix applied, in both technical and plain-language form.
18. Communication & Conflict Management — which framework you used, how it was applied in the live conversation, and what the outcome was.
19. Recommendations — how to prevent this fault recurring, and any process improvement for handling similar situations in future.

10.2 Live Role-Play Demonstration

Length: 5–8 minutes. Performed live as part of your presentation slot.

- The Team Lead plays the support agent; one other teammate plays the frustrated user (in persona, per Section 4.2).
- Should reflect the third, most escalated ticket in your sequence — the hardest version of the conversation, not the easiest.
- Must visibly use the communication framework taught by the Training & Development Coordinator.
- Should end with a clear, concrete resolution and next step communicated to the user.

10.3 Group Presentation

Length: 10 minutes plus questions. Suggested structure:

20. Scenario overview (1–2 minutes) — any presenter.
21. Technical diagnosis and fix (2 minutes) — Technical Support Lead.
22. Live role-play (5–8 minutes) — Team Lead + "user."
23. Framework and what we'd do differently next time (2 minutes) — Training & Development Coordinator.
24. Close: how the team held itself accountable (1 minute) — Documentation & QA Lead, referencing the Task Tracker.

10.4 Individual Accountability Logs & Task Tracker

Submitted by Day 10: each person's completed Individual Accountability Log (Section 8.2), and the team's final Task Tracker (Section 8.1).

11. Assessment Rubric

You will be scored across five weighted criteria, each on a 1–4 scale.

Criterion	Weight	1 — Developing	2 — Approaching	3 — Meets standard	4 — Exceeds standard
Technical resolution & IT process	25%	Fault or fix is unclear, unrealistic, or not resolved.	Fix is plausible but troubleshooting steps are thin or partly incorrect.	Clear, logical troubleshooting process and a correct, well-explained fix.	As "Meets," plus preventative recommendations and a clean explanation accessible to a non-technical audience.
Communication & conflict handling	25%	Role-play conversation is unprofessional, scripted-sounding, or doesn't address the user's frustration.	Some de-escalation attempted but inconsistent tone or unclear structure.	Confident, professional handling of a difficult conversation using a clear framework.	As "Meets," plus visible adaptability — genuinely responding to what the "user" says rather than a fixed script.
Documentation quality	20%	Incident report is incomplete, inconsistent, or unprofessional in tone.	Report covers the basics but has gaps, errors, or inconsistent tone.	Complete, accurate, professionally written incident report.	As "Meets," plus reusable knowledge-base quality: another agent could follow it unaided.
Team collaboration & individual accountability	20%	Logs/tracker missing or show little evidence of individual contribution or follow-through.	Some evidence of accountability but gaps between commitments and delivery.	Clear evidence each member delivered their role; tracker and logs are complete and honest.	As "Meets," plus evidence members proactively supported and held each other accountable.
Presentation & delivery	10%	Disorganised; unclear who did what.	Covers the scenario but roles/contributions are unclear.	Clear, well-organised presentation; each member visibly owns their part.	As "Meets," plus confident handling of follow-up questions from the audience.

Marking split: 70% of your individual mark comes from your own role deliverable (Section 7) and your Individual Accountability Log. 30% comes from the shared group deliverables (incident report, presentation, role-play) common to all four members.

12. Final Submission Checklist

Confirm every item before Day 10. Assign a name to each so nothing falls through the cracks.

- ☐ Written Incident Report, following the structure in Section 10.1
- ☐ Role-play script prepared and rehearsed at least twice
- ☐ Presentation slides covering the structure in Section 10.3
- ☐ Completed Task Tracker, up to date through Day 10
- ☐ Four Individual Accountability Logs, one per team member
- ☐ One-page communication framework brief (Role 4)
- ☐ Team debrief summary (Role 4)

Good luck. Remember: the goal isn't a perfect scenario — it's visible, honest evidence of the technical and communication skills you're building, and proof that you can be relied on for your part of a team's work.